

TSANGAI BUSINESS GROWTH SERIES · #13

The Meeting Playbook

Cut your meeting hours in half — kill the ones you don't need, shrink the rest, and let AI take the notes and chase the actions.

WHO IT'S FOR

Owners whose calendar looks like a wall of other people's priorities

TIME REQUIRED

15 minutes

WHAT YOU'LL ACHIEVE

At least 2 hours a week back on your calendar, starting this week

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

Half your meetings are status updates. Status updates don't need a meeting.

This playbook runs a 10-minute audit on your recurring meetings, gives every survivor a decision-first format, and hands the note-taking and follow-up to AI.

I ask owners to total their meeting hours for one week. The number usually shocks them — then we find that most of those hours were people reading updates to each other. Updates can be written. Meetings are for decisions. Make that one distinction and your calendar opens up like a window.

— Ray, TsangAI Consulting

WHY THIS MATTERS

8–12 hrs

Typical weekly meeting load for a small business owner

50%

How much of it is status sharing that could be a written update

25 min

The new default length — work expands to fill whatever you schedule

THE ONE IDEA

Meetings are for decisions. Updates are for writing.

Before any meeting earns a slot, it must name the decision being made. No decision? It becomes a written update that people read in two minutes. AI drafts the update, takes the notes, and chases the actions — so even the meetings you keep cost less.

Example: A property management team replaced their Monday hour-long status meeting with a written Monday morning update (AI-drafted from each person's bullet points) plus a 20-minute decision huddle. Same alignment, 40 minutes back — for seven people.

YOUR 10-MINUTE QUICK WIN

- ☐ List your recurring meetings in the audit worksheet on page 4
- ☐ Mark each: Kill, Shrink, Convert to written update, or Keep
- ☐ Cancel or shorten ONE recurring meeting right now — send the message
- ☐ Add an AI notetaker to everything that survives

Five steps to half the meetings, twice the decisions

1 Audit every recurring meeting

List them all with their real weekly cost: length × people. A "quick 30-minute sync" with four people is two hours of payroll.

Do this: Fill the worksheet on page 4. Total the hours — brace yourself.

2 Kill, shrink, or convert

No decision made in the last month? Kill it or convert it to a written update. Decision-makers only in the room; everyone else reads the summary after.

Do this: Tag every row K / S / C / Keep. Act on at least two tags today.

3 Make 25 minutes the default

Change your calendar's default event length. Meetings fill the container you give them — give them a smaller container and agendas suddenly appear.

Do this: Calendar settings → default duration → 25 minutes. Two clicks, permanent savings.

4 Put AI in every surviving meeting

A notetaker (Fathom, Otter, Fireflies) captures notes, decisions, and action items — so nobody "didn't catch that" and you never write minutes again.

Do this: Connect the notetaker to your calendar so it auto-joins everything.

5 End every meeting with the 3-line close

Last two minutes, always: What did we decide? Who does what by when? What's blocked? AI formats it from the transcript and sends it to everyone.

Do this: Run the Recap Prompt on page 4 on your next meeting's transcript.

COMMON MISTAKES

This is where most business owners get stuck.

They cancel meetings but keep the confusion — written updates must replace them, not silence. They invite everyone "to keep them in the loop" when a summary does that for free. And they collect AI meeting notes nobody ever reads — notes exist to chase actions, not to be archived.

PRO TIP

Block one meeting-free morning per week — for everyone, including you. Protect it like a client appointment. It routinely becomes the most productive four hours in the company, and your team will defend it harder than any perk.

The audit worksheet, the agenda, the recap prompt

The Meeting Audit K = Kill · S = Shrink · C = Convert to written · Keep

RECURRING MEETING	MINS	PEOPLE	HRS/WK COST	DECISION MADE?	K/S/C/KEEP
_____	___	___	___	Y / N	___
_____	___	___	___	Y / N	___
_____	___	___	___	Y / N	___
_____	___	___	___	Y / N	___
_____	___	___	___	Y / N	___

The 25-Minute Agenda

MEETING: [NAME] – DECISION NEEDED: [THE ONE DECISION]

- 0–5 min: context (pre-read sent yesterday)
- 5–18 min: options + discussion
- 18–23 min: decide + assign owners
- 23–25 min: the 3-line close

No decision listed = no meeting booked.

Could this be async? 3 quick checks

- ✓ Is it one-way information? → Written update
- ✓ Is feedback simple yes/no/edits? → Comment thread
- ✓ Real back-and-forth judgment call? → Meeting earns its slot

The Recap Prompt

Here is a meeting transcript from my [WHAT YOU DO] business. Produce: 1) DECISIONS – each in one sentence, 2) ACTIONS – task, owner, deadline as a table, 3) BLOCKED – anything waiting on someone, with who, 4) a 3-sentence summary for people who weren't there. Flag anything discussed for over 5 minutes with no decision reached. Transcript: [PASTE TRANSCRIPT]

THE MONDAY UPDATE

Replace status meetings with this: everyone sends 3 bullets (done / doing / stuck) by 9am. AI merges them into one readable update for the whole team. Five minutes, full alignment, zero meeting.

Turn this guide into one win this week.

A guide you read changes nothing. A page you fill in does. Two minutes — do it while it's fresh.

1 • WHERE I AM TODAY

Meeting hours/week today: _____ Meetings killed or shrunk: _____

2 • THE ONE THING I'M FIXING THIS WEEK

My one fix: _____

The first small step (under 15 minutes): _____

Small beats big. Pick something you can finish in one sitting.

3 • WHEN I'M DOING IT

Day: _____ Time: _____ Booked in my calendar? ☐

Open your calendar and book it now — a plan without a time slot is a wish.

4 • AFTER — WHAT HAPPENED

My result (hours saved, jobs booked, thing shipped): _____

What I'll do differently next time: _____

NOTES

KEEP THE STREAK

One fix a week is 52 upgrades a year. When this page is full, re-take the guide — a rising score is proof your systems are working.